hastily drafted in May and announced on 3 June. In late June, barely six weeks before India and Pakistan became independent, Sir Cyril Radcliffe—a lawyer who had never been to India—was tasked with drawing a line that would partition the two countries.

The Partition of British India into India and Pakistan was itself a product of complex circumstances. The Pakistan movement gained traction between 1906 and 1947, although proposals for separate homelands for Indian Hindus and Muslims go back to the late nineteenth century. (The term PAKSTAN, proposed as a Muslim homeland by a Cambridge student named Rahmat Ali in 1933, was originally an acronym for Punjab, Afghan, Kashmir, Sind and BalochisTAN.) [6] The Muslim League under Muhammad Ali Jinnah was not initially the most popular political representative of the subcontinent's Muslims. Others, including the Jamaat-e-Islami under Abul A'la al-Maududi and various Shia leaders, offered alternatives. The Muslim League gained ground after the 1930s and especially after the Congress initiated the Quit India Movement during World War II. After the war, suspicions abounded in London about the orientation of an independent India in the nascent Cold War. But as late as 1946, the prospect of a unified but federated independent India was seriously considered. [7]

At Independence in 1947, India found itself in an inhospitable international environment, quite apart from the frightful trauma of a violent Partition. India's leaders during and immediately after Independence included Mahatma Gandhi, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Chairman of the Constitution Drafting Committee and later Minister of Law and Justice B.R. Ambedkar, the second Governor-General C. Rajagopalachari (known as Rajaji), the first President Rajendra Prasad, Minister of Education Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Minister of Railways (and later finance) John Matthai, Minister of Commerce and Industry Syama Prasad Mookerjee and even the last British Viceroy and first Governor-General Lord Mountbatten. These were among the individuals who deliberated and shaped India's approach to domestic, economic, and foreign policies. [8] As vice president of the Executive Council of the Interim Government of India and later as the